

THE SERMON AT BENARES

THINKING ABOUT THE TEXT

Q1. What is a sermon? How is it different from a lecture?

Ans: A sermon is a religious speech delivered by some religious leader, priest or some saintly person in order to guide people, train them in righteousness and liberate one's ill nature. A lecture can be on any subject given to a group of people by some teacher, lecturer or professor at some school, college, university, etc. in order to make them understand something.

Q.2. When her son dies, Kisa Gotami goes from house to house. What does she ask for? Does she get it? Why not?

Ans: When Kisa Gotami's only son dies, she goes from house to house in her neighbourhood and asks each of them to give her medicine for her child to cure him. She does not get the medicine because there is no medicine which can cure a dead person. The people think that she has lost her senses.

Q3. Kisa Gotami again goes from house to house after she speaks with the Buddha. What does she ask for the second time around? Does she get it? Why not?

Ans: After speaking with the Buddha, Kisa Gotami asks her neighbours to give her a handful of mustard seeds. Although they provide her whole-heartedly, she does not get it as she is asked by the Buddha to procure it from a house where no one has lost a child, a brother, sister, wife, a husband, a parent or a friend.

Q.4. What does Kisa Gotami understand the second time that she failed to understand the first time? Was this what the Buddha wanted her to understand?

Ans: The second time Kisa Gotami understands the fate of men which flickers up and then extinguishes again like the lights of the city. She realizes that she is selfish in her grief. She knows the reality that death is common to all and no one can escape it.

Yes, it was this reality that Buddha wanted her to understand.

Q.5. Why do you think Kisa Gotami understood this only the second time? In what way did the Buddha change her understanding?

Ans: Kisa Gotami understood the second time that death is unavoidable/inevitable and common to all. She seemed selfish in her grief and did not know the terms of the world. She wanted to see her dead child alive which was quite impossible and she understood this only because of Buddha's way of teaching. Buddha changed her understanding by asking her to bring a handful of mustard seeds from a house where no one has lost a child, a husband, a wife, a parent or a friend. Although she wandered from house to house to get it but couldn't because there was no house where no death had occurred.

Q.6. How do you usually understand the idea of “selfishness”? Do you agree with Kisa Gotami that she was being “selfish in her grief”?

Ans: We usually understand the idea of “selfishness” simply by thinking of one's own benefits, needs, interests, motives etc. without caring for others. We don't agree with Kisa Gotami that she was being selfish in her grief. She was only ignorant of the terms of the world which made her think wrongly. It was only because of her affection towards her child and therefore, didn't know that death is inevitable and common to all before speaking to Buddha. But now she understood that everyone has to die and no one can escape it.